🩺 Sexual Health 2: STIs, Contraception & Safer Sex: Reading

Health · Unit 5B · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Sexual Health part 2 (Abstinence, Contraception, Condoms, STIs, HIV/HPV, Testing, Making a Plan)

Name: _____

Protecting Your Sexual Health

Abstinence means choosing not to have sex. It is the only method that is 100% effective at preventing both pregnancy and sexually transmitted infections (STIs), and anyone can choose it at any time, even if they have had sex before. Washington's Healthy Youth Act says students should learn about abstinence along with medically accurate information about other methods.

Contraception means methods that prevent pregnancy. Scientists describe effectiveness two ways: perfect use (used correctly every time) and typical use (real life, including mistakes). Long-acting methods such as the implant and the IUD are more than 99% effective and last for years. The pill, shot, patch and ring are about 91 to 96% effective with typical use because they must be used on schedule. External condoms are about 87% effective with typical use. Only condoms, and abstinence, also lower the risk of STIs.

Using a condom correctly means checking the expiration date, opening the package carefully without teeth or scissors, using a new condom every time from start to finish, and throwing it in the trash afterward. Condoms are available at pharmacies and many health clinics.

STIs are infections passed through body fluids (blood, semen, pre-ejaculate, vaginal fluids) or skin-to-skin sexual contact. Bacterial STIs, chlamydia, gonorrhea and syphilis, and trichomoniasis, caused by a parasite, are curable with medicine. Viral STIs, HIV, HPV, herpes and hepatitis B, are not curable but are treatable. People with HIV who take medicine can live long, healthy lives. Vaccines prevent HPV, which can cause several cancers, and hepatitis B. Young people ages 15 to 24 get about half of all new STIs in the U.S.

Many STIs have no symptoms, so testing is the only way to know. In Washington, teens 14 and older can get STI testing and treatment without a parent's permission, and that care is confidential. Testing sites can be found at gettested.cdc.gov. Making a plan ahead of time, knowing your limits, talking with partners and trusted adults, and remembering that you can always say no, helps people make choices that match their values.

Check your reading

1. Why is typical-use effectiveness lower than perfect-use effectiveness?

2. Which two choices protect against both pregnancy and STIs?

3. Why is testing important even if a person feels fine?